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Is Reality TV Neoliberal?

Guy Redden[1]

Abstract

Reality TV is a distinctive mode of television programming that has developed exclusively in the last twenty years, raising the question of how it is of its times. Reality shows have often been described as "neoliberal" in their logic. They typically present participants as self-responsible enterprising authors of their own lives in ways consistent with the valorization of market relations by neoliberal theorists. I argue for and expand on this interpretation, arguing the role of the "ordinary people" they feature largely is to perform competitive entrepreneurial subjectivity without expectation of fair recompense, but in the hope of attaining extraordinary rewards. Hereby media industries construct narrative worlds consistent with the economic basis on which they employ, but also with recent neoliberal political economy that has been marked by the decline of collective social support and rising inequality among citizens.

Keywords

reality TV, neoliberalism, Big Brother, American Idol, makeover, lifestyle television, television

> In a society of consumers, turning into a desirable and desired commodity is the stuff of which dreams, and fairy tales, are made.
>
> —Bauman (2007, 13)

The rise of reality TV has arguably defined the pop cultural landscape of the early millennium (Grazian 2010, 68). According to Ross (2009, 36), in the United States it constituted over 20 percent of primetime network programming since 2001, and much other media—from newspaper reportage to online commentary and "soft" current affairs—tracks both the shows themselves and the stories of the people they feature. The rise of reality is tied in with other transformations, such as media convergence, the

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turn toward celebrity culture (Turner 2006, 2010), and the international trade in formats (Moran 2009). The media industries have hit on successful and replicable formulas. Perhaps most significant of all, "reality" denotes cost-effective production. The defining focus on ordinary people in nominally live scenarios dispenses with the need for professional actors and scriptwriters. Talent is usually free, or cheap relative to returns. Reality is an economical way to fill up schedules in a multichannel environment and the celebrification of participants creates branded personae that can generate further content across platforms (Grindstaff and Murray 2015).

However, is it adequate to suggest that the corporate agent "industry" has autonomously fashioned its new killer app in line with strictly "industrial" criteria? Such an emic reading would fail to consider that changes in industry imperatives might themselves be related to broader socio-cultural patterns, as might the narratives and themes of the shows themselves. One interpretation, summarized (but not fully endorsed) by Turner (2010), is that the reality turn is part of a larger democratization of the public sphere through media forms less driven by cultural elites than by the interests of the ordinary people. Yet, though the democratization view indicates that the reality turn consists in certain inclusive and progressive social relations, others argue that it should be viewed more critically. For example, Andrejevic (2004) proposes that reality shows submit participants and audiences to processes of surveillance through which media corporations benefit economically from their personal consumption and labor. Others stress that reality television reinforces social distinctions by representing many ordinary people unfavorably relative to gendered or middle-class norms (see Wood and Skeggs 2011).

The aim here is not to rehearse or resolve these debates, however. It is to develop a line of interpretation often associated with more critical readings, namely, that reality is, in some sense, "neoliberal." After over a decade of research, numerous scholars have identified neoliberal rationalities in programs or subgenres and/or the relations of their production. Yet there is little sustained discussion of the relationship between neoliberalism and reality TV as an overall mode. And some, such as Flew (2014), suggest neoliberalism has become too fuzzy a concept to reveal much of intellectual note about TV or many other phenomena. However, I argue that neoliberalism should be considered a key element of the broader formative socio-historical context in which it has gained such rapid cultural currency. Furthermore, recent debates as to whether the neoliberalism concept is useful are not merely scholarly. They raise important political questions about contiguous links between public policies and regressive social trends, particularly the return of rising inequality in recent decades (Piketty 2014). If neoliberalism has societal level consequences, it is also necessary to ask if neoliberal cultural forms, potentially including reality TV, play a role in its legitimation.

Although space does not allow for exhaustive analysis, the working proposition of this article is that reality TV *is* neoliberal, not in the sense that every aspect or variant of it can be explained through recourse to the concept, but that neoliberal logic is evident in both the main recurring textual features of reality programming and in the material conditions of their production. This argument first requires a fairly extensive discussion of theories of neoliberalism. On this basis, the article

then briefly considers how neoliberal patterns are evident in the codes of subgenres most commonly identified as constituting reality: docusoaps, gamedocs, makeovers, and talent shows (Grindstaff and Murray 2015, 117). It ends with a consideration of neoliberal production logics in the cultural industries and the suggestion that their relationship with neoliberal discourses in the shows constitutes ideological legitimation of neoliberal sociality.

Desperately Seeking Neoliberalism

According to Birch (2015, 572) the one thing on which most scholars working on the topic agree "is that neoliberalism can be broadly defined as the extension and installation of competitive markets into all areas of life." Neoliberalism is something more specific than capitalism per se, whereas it is also general in the sense that market rationalities are being further extended throughout all kinds of social institutions and contexts. So it is that otherwise different phenomena and practices can be considered neoliberal when they exist in certain pro-market forms: from approaches to development, to managerialism or housing policy (Clarke 2008, 138). For Clarke the problem is that as a notion neoliberalism is both omnipresent and promiscuous. It can apparently be found everywhere and gets hooked up with all kinds of particulars.

However, others have taken the challenge of pinning it down less as a sign of its redundancy than as an indicator of the flexible ways that neoliberalism is reticulated across diverse social sites without necessarily making them "the same" or replacing other social logics. Rather than taking neoliberalism as a fixed value, much work views it as variable historical processes by which extant social relations are modified. "Neoliberalization" may take a range of path-dependent forms and become articulated and disarticulated with other social and cultural forces—and, far from constituting lazy analysis, recognizing this can lead to pertinent insights into the means by which diverse changes effecting marketization actually take place (Peck 2013).

In this sense, neoliberalism-in-general is basically the "pattern that connects." Probably the best-known account of the overall pattern is that of David Harvey. For Harvey (2007), neoliberalism is a class project designed to restore the incomes and rates of return to capital owned by economic elites whose share of wealth was threatened by redistributive Keynesian social democratic capitalism. In Harvey's reading, neoliberalism is based on philosophies developed from the 1930s onward by Hayek, Roepke, von Mises, and other members of the Mont Pelerin society who argued that markets—in allowing actors to pursue their desires with freedom to transact and compete—are the most efficient mechanisms for social allocation of resources. It later attained greater force through corporate sponsorship and Chicago economics, which advocated that neoliberal economic policies be implemented as a response to the 1970s stagflation crisis. The result, according to Harvey, was restoration of elite economic power through "accumulation by dispossession." Wealth and entitlements were redistributed from the majority population to the rich, who are best placed with the necessary resources to capitalize on market opportunities that public policies increasingly favor. Indeed, upward redistribution in the decades of neoliberal policy has now

been empirically confirmed, with wealth and income inequality in countries that undertook reform earliest and deepest (the United States and the United Kingdom) now rising back toward close to record levels (Piketty 2014).

Yet one of the problems of attributing neoliberalism with societal consequences is that it is not an overt political platform such that its promises could be compared with its results. The "neoliberal thought collective" has nonetheless been highly organized and influential (Dean 2014), and classical neoliberal socio-economic philosophy on which it is based is general in nature, supporting the idea that its principles can be applied in varied ways to different kinds of social organization. Interestingly, Hayek accepted that markets do not deliver social security, and that lives shaped by them might be subject to risk and arbitrary fortune in spite of one's best efforts (Rehmann 2013, 280–81). However, he dealt with the problem of inequality of outcome not by arguing for compensations against it (beyond minimal welfare measures to allow survival) or restrictions on markets, but by deconstructing the very concept of egalitarian social justice on which democratic rights to social goods have been based. For Hayek the idea is mythic because society as a collective construct cannot owe an individual anything. Injustices can only be defined as infractions on the right to property and self-determination of individuals by other identifiable agents. In the aggregate people will be better off, according to Hayek, if they bear responsibility for their own lives through markets, thus unleashing the spirit of competitive enterprise that supposedly creates wealth.

Neoliberals did not agree on everything (Dardot and Laval 2014), but did not have to for their lines of thought to be developed and applied in practices that both delegitimized particular collectively organized forms of social support and legitimized the extension of markets. As Jessop (2016) has stressed, if neoliberalism is best thought of in processual terms, it is necessary to identify the main dimensions in which it has sponsored related socio-economic changes. He identifies six key planks via which the Fordist/Keynesian compromise settlement between capital and labor has been undone in favor of capital owners: "liberalization, deregulation, privatization, market proxies in the public sector, internationalization, and cuts in direct taxation" (487). Across numerous jurisdictions (including all Anglophone countries to some extent) regulations seen to inhibit market freedom, such as labor laws, prudential restrictions on financial markets and international trade tariffs have been rolled back, as has direct government social spending on welfare and social services, to make way for tax cuts seen to give capital owner incentives to invest in markets. Accordingly, some of the common features of highly neoliberalized polities are the precarity of employment conditions (as the right of employers to hire and fire has been prioritized over employee rights), workfare, and similar welfare programs (that cut welfare entitlements back and/or make access to them conditional to encourage the unemployed to take low-paid work), high levels of private debt (as consumers turn to liberalized finance markets to make up for stagnant real wages), privatization of state assets, and cuts to or privatization of many services previously provided to citizens by governments (Jessop 2016).

The neoliberalism argument is essentially that such developments are not isolated, but related to the general orientation—a combination of roll-back elements that dismantle collectivist arrangements and the roll out of new regulatory strategies to foster

marketization (Peck 2010). However, this does not mean there is a single kind of neoliberal state. Jessop notes that different combinations of the key planks can be in evidence and some may not even feature in some localized versions. Actually existing neoliberalisms are variegated, adapted to the socio-political lie of the land, and are not necessarily the only or dominant governmental logic when evident (Ong 2006). In these terms, neoliberalization as a general socio-historical pattern is uneven and multifarious, not linear or monological, and it overlaps with other phenomena such as financialization, the rise of neoclassical economics and globalization. Thus, for proponents of its intellectual usefulness neoliberalism remains a complex, ongoing historical transformation that will not render into a stable, pure form for analytic convenience. This is not to defend vague and reductive uses of the term that fail to consider this complexity, but is to defend the need to take the general pattern of marketization and its social consequences seriously, both intellectually and politically.

However, in themselves political economy approaches that demonstrate policy pathways shed limited light on the means by which neoliberal principles become socially normalized and operative. Some, like Harvey (2007), suggest that the neoliberal thought collective has exerted successful persuasive influence over policy at elite political levels in both democratic and non-democratic countries. Others argue that in democratic populations where neoliberal political economy avoids direct public scrutiny, its principles have been annexed to populism to attain broader buy-in. Stuart Hall (1979) famously argued that Thatcherism—Thatcher being a Hayek follower who proclaimed shortly after becoming leader of the Conservative Party that his *The Constitution of Liberty* would be her Bible—was possible because of a law-and-order–focused "authoritarian populism." Britain's working classes were enjoined to defend property owners and self-responsible citizens who strive for the welfare of their families against the threats posed by criminals and apparently dysfunctional collectivists such as strikers and welfare recipients.

This raises the question of whether people other than economic and governmental elites assent to neoliberalism, and if so how. According to Rehmann (2013), neoliberal hegemony only makes sense if ideas serving those who benefit from the inequality created by competitive markets have become socially organized to influence the majority of people who do not. He cites Hall as important to the task of interpreting how as he shows how popular ideology works not simply by circulating falsehoods (as in the "false consciousness" model) but by modifying existing discourses that resonate as true with people, such as in appealing to the family as the "natural" locus of welfare and solidarity, in a constructed distinction with the paternalism of the overweening state. Importantly, in this view the language through which neoliberal moral sentiments become normal can work through manipulation of people's existing beliefs, interests, and experiences.

In a different vein, Foucault and governmentality theorists have focused on how neoliberal market thinking has become translated into multiple forms that allow direct "economization" of social life. In *The Birth of Biopolitics*, Foucault (2008) argued that neoliberalism was a particular interventionist philosophy distinct from previous laissez-faire liberal economics that proposed markets should be left to run

their own course. Instead it looks for ways to re-regulate the social to construct new market relations at every opportunity. In particular, Foucault highlighted how the Chicago School microeconomics of Gary Becker models all social relations and human action on neoliberal conceptions of markets. This is to view agents as self-responsible, competitive, and enterprising—at least under the "right" neoliberal conditions. This led Foucault to argue that neoliberalism constitutes a shift away from forms of power that directly seek to shape the behavior of individuals. Instead governmentality could become an "environmental type" in which configuration of the rules of any social practice could manage the sets of options by which otherwise free agents may be spurred to meet desired governmental goals as an outcome of the games of "optimization" of choices they undertake while pursuing their own interests—as people do in idealized descriptions of markets.

Accordingly, Foucauldian writers suggest the successful diffusion of neoliberalism takes place not simply through the implementation of government policies or persuasive rhetoric. Rather neoliberal market rationalities issuing from a general philosophy of the social are circulated across institutions, are made operative through numerous languages and mechanisms, and are productive of neoliberal subject positions that enact entrepreneurial self-responsibility. So it is that by appealing to ideals such as freedom, choice, empowerment, flexibility, and competition, "Neo-liberal strategies of rule, found in diverse realms including workplaces, educational institutions and health and welfare agencies, encourage people to see themselves as individualized and active subjects responsible for enhancing their own well being" (Larner 2000, 13).

Wendy Brown (2015, 10) takes the line further to argue that "neoliberalism transmogrifies every human domain and endeavor, along with humans themselves, according to a specific image of the economic." For Brown, not only are governments and organizations run via neoliberal logic, it has become normalized across everyday sites, practices, and consumption. Through practices as diverse as pursuing social media ratings, strategic social engagements, or self-help "today's homo oeconomicus is an intensely constructed and governed bit of human capital tasked with improving and leveraging its competitive positioning and with enhancing its (monetary and nonmonetary) portfolio value across all of its endeavors and venues." For Brown, the price of this general economization is the undoing of the demos and the ongoing replacement of imaginaries and deliberative practices based on rights, fairness, equality or any other non-market normative principles.

Neoliberalizing Television

The point of the discussion so far is not to prove we live in a "fully" neoliberal society, nor that we are all "perfect" neoliberal subjects now. Few in recent neoliberalism studies hold such simplistic positions. Neoliberalism is not a unified political program, capitalism per se, the mode of production, or the only political rationality in the world. However, it is a pervasive multifaceted approach to (re)organizing the social relations of capitalism that has societal level consequences including inequality, precarity, and the individualization of risk. It works by rolling back social limitations on market

activity and its consequences, and instead administers conditions on which market competition and value accumulation may be extended (Lazzarato 2009). It deserves to be taken seriously, as does the idea that cultural forms may articulate with or express its logic. The rest of the article proposes that reality television is one conduit through which this has happened.

The 1990s can be seen as the key decade in the consolidation of neoliberalism as by then successive governments across the political spectrum had endorsed related policies while the fall of communism signaled the apparent end of alternatives internationally (Duggan 2012). Several scholars have made the case that reality TV overall is a neoliberal televisual form that developed in the same time period as the normalization of neoliberal common sense. Writing from the U.S. context, Laurie Ouellette and James Hay (2008, and numerous other publications), Anna McCarthy (2007) and David Grazian (2010) all propose that reality shows depict people navigating various life challenges in line with new constructions of citizenship in a neoliberal post-welfare society. They are presented as authors of their own lives and responsible for their own fates, which are seen as outcomes of the skills, choices, and efforts of the interior, psychologized self rather than social forces. Such narratives present both successes and failures as just deserts of the person, create drama out of attempts at self-improvement, and generally endorse a privatized approach to welfare consistent with reduced expectations of social support. However, to further develop the case that reality TV is neoliberal more specific attention must be given to the representations of ordinary people and principal narratives across key subgenres.

Makeovers

Makeover shows came to dominate early evening weekday programming just before the turn of the millennium (Moseley 2000). Earlier lifestyle television typically featured experts delivering generic, didactic "how-to" instruction in gardening, DIY, and cookery. The makeover, however, takes ordinary people as case studies. The new structure sees personal tastes in a particular sphere of lifestyle forensically examined by experts and subject to a problem-solution logic through which better choices, and consequently lives, are achieved. The key lesson is that actively modifying one's attitudes, behavior, and consumer lifestyle enhances personal well-being to an apparently life-transforming extent.

The makeover can be read as a textual projection of the idea that consumption improves people's fortunes in a market society (Redden 2007). It typically depicts the passage of a person's life from being worth less to being worth more through means of elective consumption in areas such as fashion, surgery, and home decoration. In the narrative, improving oneself or one's possessions does not just satisfy the self, but it also pays dividends in the way that an investment leads to future life yield. Success is confirmed in the eyes of others who evaluate the transformation, whether in recognition of a beach body, being dressed for success, or the more saleable home. The social relation is one in which people validate in others the economic logic of personal value accrual. These elements together create distinctive self-optimizing characters who

drive narratives of self-actualization consistent with neoliberal privatization of welfare (McMurria 2008; Ouellette and Hay 2008; Sender 2006). People are walked through how to form appropriate subjectivity, how to adopt the kinds of monitoring and self-reflection required to manage one's own life as an individual citizen responsible for one's fortune to the last detail and largely through appropriation of commodities.

Of course, there is nothing wrong with seeking to enjoy one's life and makeovers can be read as democratizing as they help participants fulfill life goals. But the discursive limits of the makeover logic betray the fact that change is compulsory, a generalized requirement. Whatever variations among texts may otherwise be—for example, in being to some degree body positive or body shaming—they are always variations of the social expectation that people should increase their value in the manner of a personal enterprise and thereby realize the good life in the form of an individual project. For Hearn (2008), this particular conception of empowerment deals with the problem of individualized insecurity generated by neoliberalism itself by imagining a super competent "self-branding" subject who can capitalize and supposedly thrive on it. This vision of the good life is different from one based on egalitarian social goals and rights to which all should be entitled amid the vagaries of individual fortune. It is *not* that the makeover is exclusionary or elitist, but that inclusion is to sign up to these terms. Indeed, as Sender and Sullivan (2008) argue with reference to *The Biggest Loser*, the flipside of the makeover's ethic of self-made welfare is that people who apparently fail to self-optimize by normative social standards, such as the overweight or obese, are failures who have only themselves to blame. Failure is failure of the will. The only kinds of support routinely presented in the makeover are those of charity and consumer advice, which are imagined to activate the recipients' power to overcome any kind of misfortune, marginality, or deprivation (Becker 2006; McMurria 2008). So it is that "needy subjects" need only improve their capacity to navigate whatever life throws up as opposed to needing the assistance of social support aimed at equality of life conditions (Vander Schee and Kline 2013).

Gamedocs and Docusoaps

The gamedoc is less often discussed as a "genre," but this is possibly because of its close association with reality TV overall. Although the makeover is the recasting of lifestyle programming in a reality mode, the gamedoc centers on people in a contrived social situation that involves game show dynamics (Mast 2009). Emerging just a few years behind similarly hybrid docusoaps such as the reality crime shows of the 1990s, it was at the vanguard of the observational programming forms that transformed the documentary tradition and first started to attract the label "reality" (Corner 2002). At the turn of the millennium, *Big Brother* and *Survivor* were the first examples of reality event TV. Both are effectively large scale popularity contests comprising multiple episodes across a week. Participants immersed in an intense "social experiment" vie with each other to win assigned tasks and thus gain favor with voting audiences that decide their fates. They have been joined by numerous other shows in which ordinary people seek to win a social contest resulting in prizes for some and elimination for others.

Whereas the makeover is an individual case study in self-actualization, the gamedoc emphasizes competition between enterprising individuals. Indeed, much of the drama derives precisely from characters who are immersed in a challenging environment together, forcing them to cooperate while they are also pitted against each other. The narratives generated not only articulate the key neoliberal ideas of enterprise and competition, but they also revolve around extreme display of these qualities at the limit. Gamedocs are not about displaying "bits" of knowledge or skill as in the established game show, but the stress testing of the whole person and their subjective capacities. This emphasis is created by the intense situation, usually involving social deprivation, isolation and often survival, competing virtually "24/7," constantly being subjected to the gaze of those who determine winning and losing performances, and compulsion to give maximum effort for each and every task in an unpredictable environment fraught with insecurity and risk—for a chance to win it all, or nothing.

As Ouellette and Hay (2008) argue (185–86), shows like *Survivor* nominally involve much "teamwork," but they recast group governance to be less about what individuals contribute to the well-being of the collective than what the individual can get from it. In the course of this, they police individual contributions such that those identified as less productive or self-responsible—those who fail to "go for it" or "in going for it"—are ritually admonished. Although this is consistent with post-welfare, anti-collectivist views of the social, it is also in a specific sense a projection of neoliberal approaches to work. This is seen in shows such as *The Apprentice* that explicitly replay challenges of the demanding neoliberal workplace (Couldry and Littler 2011). However, more generally gamedoc contestants are depicted in work roles, laboring toward desired rewards under tough conditions prescribed by the format. Along these lines Couldry (2008) reads the gamedoc *Big Brother* as both actual work of participants under precarious neoliberal conditions and a theatrical representation of the same. For Couldry, these reality workers enact acceptance of internal subjection to external demands—even when arbitrary, give commitment to the employer's agenda beyond reasonable limits, display maximum personal flexibility in the face of regime inflexibility, and expect no job security or a guaranteed or fair return for their labor. In this he sees the gamedoc as translation of "market primacy" and its demands that people become competitive, self-responsible, flexible, committed, and endlessly passionate in the course of fulfilling the aims of the corporations that employ them, but that also seek to free themselves from reciprocal obligations in deregulated labor markets. As Grazian (2010, 70) observes, each episode of a gamedoc ends with symbolically legitimized layoffs in a ritual of summary dismissal.

The protean striving self of the gamedoc—who has to constantly demonstrate one's value in all action, does so on unstable grounds where games of self-optimization are structurally inseparable from inequality of outcomes. Indeed, the latter are celebrated in the high-stake winner-takes-all formats. But even in the more naturalistic setting of the docusoap, which lacks a formal contest, the soap-style narratives often express exaggerated concern with comparing people's fortunes and behaviors in competitive milieux where people from housewives (*Real Housewives of . . ., Wife Swap*) to aspirant youths (*Jersey Shore, Geordie Shore*) strive for personal success and recognition

in their social circles. In this sense, the common element in observing different categories of "ordinary person" seems to be "the concept of performance itself" (Grindstaff 2013, 341). Whatever the role played, people are constantly evaluated such that performativity "becomes a quality of the cultural construction of ordinariness" that allows reality contestants to accrue value as people. The ultimate prize of this logic is achieving celebrity status through one's narrative, a concern that, as Grindstaff (2013, 341) proposes, distinctively "reflects the ascendance of neoliberalism and the impulse to perform, brand, and promote the self according to neoliberal imperatives."

The Talent Show

If narrative interest in people "accruing value" through their personal performance is evident across reality genres, none take it to the level of the contemporary reality talent show, which is about systematic production of stars. By the mid-2000s, talent shows such as *Idol* and *X-Factor* had superseded the gamedoc as the leading edge of event TV. Although they are based on one of the oldest light entertainment genres in broadcasting, the key differences from earlier talent shows are precisely what makes the new examples reality TV. Classic talent searches would typically feature new crops of happy-go-lucky contestants popping up on a weekly basis. They would be introduced with a brief chat before performing and being judged. That was the be-all and end-all of their tilt at fame for most, though weekly winners would return for the finals at the end of the season. In contrast, the new shows embed performances in elaborate narratives about ordinary people and their dreams of transformation, narratives that run across whole seasons (Reijnders et al. 2007). Instead of different people appearing each week, a group of contestants is selected from "nationwide" talent searches starting in the community. Over coming weeks, they are then absorbed in an intense improvement project, often living together 24/7 and undertaking rapid learning in singing, dancing, or another art under the tutelage of industry experts while being subjected to incessant testing. The contest is structured through elimination rounds, meaning each week at least one aspirant's narrative ends and the field is eventually whittled down to the single winner whose dream is fulfilled.

The talent show combines familiar reality elements: the immersive interpersonal contest of the gamedoc, the docusoap concern with observing and judging people, and the before–after personal transformation narrative of the makeover. Everything that can be said to articulate neoliberal rationalities around work, welfare, and fate in those subgenres applies, but in a heightened form that emphasizes opportunity and overcoming. The prize on offer is literal "whole life" change—a contract to be an entertainment star, and the nationwide search technically extends the reach of opportunity to all. The overcoming of obstacles by those who progress legitimates the neoliberal idea that anyone can make it, regardless of socio-economic resources (Boyd 2012; Hasinoff 2008). They only need to pull themselves up by their bootstraps, finding agency in the form of personal qualities that are brought out through pure motivation. This in itself stresses equality of opportunity (to go for unequal rewards) over the equality of outcome that was a tenet of social democracy (Redden 2008). It reproduces the neoliberal emphasis

on participating, but through markets that generate inherently unstable and unequal social outcomes, and that also increases the subjection of individuals to the demands of other potentially more powerful market actors whose satisfaction they must seek.

Acceptance of inequality of reward plays a key role in this picture. The shows guarantee the failure of most who try in a winner-takes-all format, but that is not the new element. It is the combination of inequality of outcome with acceptance of doing "whatever it takes" even to be a contender. That involves considerably more than turning up and giving it a go. Contestants work ceaselessly for a chance, but in situations over which they have little control, while paradoxically they must be held to account for and take responsibility for their circumstances. Such "neoliberal learners and workers must not question the fairness of expectations made of them and decisions made concerning them, only their own performance, quality and commitment" (Windle 2010, 260).

In fact, this amounts to a redefinition of fairness in which self-cultivation, learning for experience, and a chance to win are cast as inherent compensations for labor. In such terms it seems natural that only the best are rewarded and the rest should be grateful for the formative opportunity. Patterson's (2015) interviews with former contestants affirm the internalization of such views. Despite detailing the physical and mental toll of relentless pressure testing, long days, irregular sleep, social isolation, and editorial stoking of social tensions that make for emotion and drama, the contestants accepted, somewhat paradoxically, that they alone were responsible for their performances. The message for young people is that success in such an environment—where you are worth what your last performance is judged to be—is a calculative project of personal reinvention determined by one's personal choices in response to opportunity (Allen and Mendick 2013). It turns out however, that one must undertake such work on oneself in exchange only for a *chance* of extraordinary reward, neatly reproducing what Mirowski (2013) refers to as the neoliberal idea of "snapprenticeship."

So it is people are not only exposed to insecurity and uneven rewards that characterize neoliberal labor markets and their mechanisms such as performance management, inflated elite pay and unpaid internships (Duménil and Lévy 2004), but to an extent greater than the gamedoc, their justification. Indeed, the talent show could be considered a fairytale in which people dream to join the new hyper-remunerated "superstar-manager" class that Piketty (2014) identifies, in combination with stagnant or falling real incomes of large sections of most populations, as the key driver of the return to rising inequality across societies.

Neoliberal Ideology?

When considered together, reality genres are about more than the "people watching" with which they are nominally associated. People rarely appear as they would in normal life. The shows are social spaces specifically structured to test and judge their performances against ideals of maximization in matters of consumption, labor, and social competition. People are put into situations that bring out certain qualities and narratives around personally accruing value, improving, becoming a better, more competitive self in response to specific cues of one's environment. This is not and cannot

be about social inclusion of some undifferentiated "ordinary person" on "their own terms." To appear is to endorse the terms of the constructed game: the challenge of publicly demonstrating a particular kind of outstanding self that lives up to externally required standards, and acceptance that success or failure in this bid is one's own responsibility. The logic throughout is that of the productive individuality of the strategic citizen of neoliberal governance who is asked to conduct "his or her life, and that of his or her family, as a kind of enterprise, seeking to enhance and capitalize on existence itself through calculated acts and investments" (Rose 1999, 164).

As with the neoliberalism concept itself, however, caveats are in order. None of this is to say that every aspect of all shows is neoliberal. As previously discussed, it is now widely accepted that neoliberal rationalities reshape formations creating hybrid assemblages with socio-cultural elements that are other than neoliberal. Singing and dancing, soapie-type interpersonal drama, how to live a life, and games are not inherently neoliberal phenomena. Indeed, as Rehmann (2013, 298) proposes, neoliberalism should not be considered the content of the social so much as an underlying "operating system" that formats it in ways consistent with market rationalities. Accordingly, through the organizing effects of specific kinds of narrative, reality TV "neoliberalizes" cultural texts (such as TV genres) and cultural practices (such as dancing), that also have broader meanings, histories, and potentials.

At one level it is possible to argue that the affinities between reality narratives and neoliberalism can be demonstrated and leave it at that. However, the question of exactly how its influence spreads is an important topic in studies of neoliberalism. Rehmann (2013) has argued that its hegemony requires a serious reconsideration of ideology theory (including the Foucauldian discourse/power models that have destabilized it) so as to develop understanding of imbrications between material and ideational factors. If as Vago (1980, 99) puts it, ideology boils down to "the legitimation and rationalization of behavior, the provision of basis for solidarity in a group or society, and the motivation of individuals for specific types of action" then we can at least propose that reality TV provides moral orientations that facilitate buy-in for neoliberalism—in a way that is somewhat different from elite-to-elite influence or populist trickery.

One possibility lies in connecting discourse and political economy approaches. Although there might be a case that media content remediates discourses of its context, this alone does not account for the presence of neoliberal rationalities in specific genres. It is here that we must consider organizational and material factors, as Sean Phelan (2014) does when analyzing the development of neoliberal news and current affairs. A starting point for understanding the "neoliberalization" of genres is acknowledging widespread restructuring of media systems themselves through neoliberal principles of privatization, deregulation, liberalization, and globalization. These reforms have effected greater commercial logic, even in media enterprises that remain in public ownership, such that management imperatives for profit dominate over other values in media production, journalism, and programming (Phelan 2014, 17–18). Along similar lines we can extend an argument of Turner (2006, 2010) that reality TV is part of a shift toward "constructive" media industries—ones less concerned with representing social life as it exists beyond media than with constructing media content directly

in their own commercial interests. Accordingly, the demotic populism of participatory media effects a sustained intervention "into the construction of people's desires, cultural identities and expectations of the real" (2010, 23), but one in which "the media industries still remain in control of the symbolic economy" and "attempt to operate this economy in the service of their own interests" (2006, 157).

Thus, reality can be thought of as an industry innovation that "includes" ordinary people on terms amenable to the economic interests of media corporations: as free to cheap laborers from whom maximum on-screen value can be extracted and as potentially lucrative cross-promotable celebrities. Although talent show and gamedoc participants often have to give up paid work for filming, normally classified as "contestants" and not labor, they are rarely paid more than a stipend or accorded employment protections. The first-generation U.S. reality shows such as *Cops* were produced in response to the 1988 Writers Guild of America strike, and from there, the industry developed a form of programming immune from industrial relations provisions necessary for actors and scriptwriters (Grazian 2010, 69). Unpaid reality labor is the polar opposite of unionized labor with job security and collective bargaining power over terms of work. Participants are routinely signed up to confidential contracts that waive rights, their power over production and representation, and rights to appear in other media, while committing any future media work to the show's media management on terms that highly favor it (Collins 2008).

The actual conditions of reality TV production are routinely ones in which participants are sweated to their emotional drama-producing limits through long days in exchange for the chance to appear. But these are also the conditions of reality TV production workers, most of whom are in precarious below-the-line employment in one the least unionized but most profitable of television sectors (Ross 2009). Hesmondhalgh and Baker's ethnography of reality TV production work found junior researchers contracted by the job under pressure to bring the show together and demonstrate their self-enterprise in hope of future work. A key part of this was to maintain pressure on contestants to elicit more emotional and dramatic performances. Both contestants and production workers share a precarious environment where their value was determined by others' reading of their last performance.

As this material environment is structured through neoliberal principles, it is logical that the symbolic economies of reality TV are also. Reality is part of a participatory media turn that, in the words of Ross, is "clearly aligned with the neoliberal ethos of the jackpot economy—we are all participants in a game that rewards only a few." In this we are enjoined to undertake "sacrificial labor and self-exploitation" to have a chance of being part of that game, in which it turns out "people-to-people communication could be little more than a free input for the latest model of capital accumulation" (Ross 2009, 137). Hence, if ideology exists when ideas are mobilized to support the interests of powerful groups that benefit from them, reality genres are ideological, in the sense outlined by Hall (1996)—that is, not through some vague society-wide distortion of meanings, but in that specific identifiable relations of production compatible with the economic interests of specific groups have lines of influence over the ways that aspects of the social world are represented.

As Rehmann (2013) argues, popular neoliberal hegemony depends on promises of individual emancipation and self-activation contra collectivism, despite the self-mobilization on offer being subordinated to markets already stacked toward outcomes for the powerful. No doubt, the promises of participation are extended to all, regardless of social background or identity, but such thinking "empties out classed, gendered or racialized power differentials" that need to be addressed for genuine social inclusion and egalitarian outcomes (Ringrose and Walkerdine 2008, 229). And as the rewards of both media economies and global knowledge economies increasingly flow to a few, many with diminished actual life chances are left above all else to aspire as individuals (P. Brown et al. 2010). Or they can seek actual "opportunities" that may involve discounting their own labor to the prices capital is now willing and allowed to pay. In such circumstances, reality TV would seem a particularly potent form of what Berlant (2011) calls the "cruel optimism" of a capitalist society that generates fantasies of the good life while the means by which most ordinary people may realize them are diminished.

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